

“ WE HAVE BEEN **TOO LONG IN DARKNESS.** ONCE ALREADY WE HAVE **BEEN IN THE LIGHT,** AND WE **WANT IT AGAIN.** ”

Alexander Dubcek, Czechoslovakian leader, 1989



Huge crowds demonstrate for the end of communist rule in Hungary. The Republic of Hungary was proclaimed on October 23, marking a new era in Europe.



to keep meeting every Monday until their demands were met. On October 9, the army refused to fire on the crowds. Honecker was ousted from office on October 18.

After the fall of Honecker's regime, the leader of the East Berlin communist party, Günter Schabowski, announced on November 9 that the **border with West Berlin would be opened** for "private trips abroad." That night, 50,000 East Berliners rushed to the Berlin Wall (see 1961). The guards let them pass. The crowds were met by ecstatic West Berliners on the other side. The next morning, they started **bringing the wall down.**

On December 3, the US and the USSR met in Malta and declared the **end of the Cold War.** At a joint news conference held on board the Soviet cruise ship, *Maxim Gorky*, President George Bush (b. 1924) and President Mikhail Gorbachev (b. 1931) announced plans for **substantial reductions in weapons** in Europe. Praised by those outside the USSR, internally it placed Gorbachev's position as Soviet leader at risk (see pp.442-43).

Kosovo, an autonomous province of Serbia, had been clamoring for independence since the death of Josip Tito (see 1980). There was increasing

ethnic tension between Serbs and Albanians for control of the province. Serbs argued that they were being persecuted by the majority Albanians. When **Slobodan Milosevic** became president of Serbia on May 8, he used this alleged persecution as a justification for **stripping Kosovo of its autonomy** and became a champion of Serbian nationalism.

On December 20, **US troops invaded Panama** in a bid to oust dictator Manuel Noriega. Over 200 civilians died in the fighting. A new government, headed by Guillermo Endara, was installed.

In New York, **Wall Street suffered a crash** on Friday October, as a failed buyout of United Airlines caused share values to plummet. It was the second largest drop of the Dow



Galileo space probe

Named after astronomer Galilei Galileo, the probe travelled a distance of more than 4.5 billion km (nearly 3 billion miles), circling Jupiter 34 times.

Jones industrial average, a stock market index, in history, and became known as the **"Friday-the-13th mini-crash."**

The US launched *Galileo*, an unmanned probe to Jupiter and its moons, aboard the space shuttle *Atlantis* on October 18. At a cost of \$1.5 billion, *Galileo* reached its final destination in 1994 after taking detailed images of Venus and the asteroid belt on the way.

The Wall falls

An East German border guard peers through a hole in the Berlin Wall, brought down in 1989, a potent symbol of the end of communism.

- September 11 Hungary opens border to Austria
- September 26 Last of Vietnamese troops leave Cambodia
- October 19 State of emergency in San Francisco after an earthquake
- November 7 Entire cabinet in East Germany resigns
- November 16 Violence escalates in El Salvador civil war
- November 17-December 29 Velvet Revolution in Czechoslovakia
- November 24 Entire politburo in Prague quits
- November 18 Mass demonstrations in Bulgaria demanding reform
- December 14 Patricio Aylwin elected president of Chile
- December 16 Bulgaria's assembly approves sweeping political reforms
- December 22 Death of Irish writer, Samuel Beckett (b. 1906)
- December 29 Vaclav Havel becomes Czechoslovakia's new president
- December 30 Communist rule abolished in Romania
- August 24 Noncommunist leader, Tadeusz Mazowiecki, elected in Poland
- September 13 Mass demonstration in Cape Town, South Africa, against apartheid
- October 18 Erich Honecker ousted as East German leader
- October 23 Birth of Hungarian Republic
- November 10 East Berliners pour through checkpoint at Berlin Wall to West Berlin
- November 18 Mass demonstrations in Bulgaria demanding reform
- December 3 Cold War declared over by the US and the USSR
- December 14 Sakharov, Soviet physicist (b. 1921)
- December 21 US troops invade Panama; Noriega evades capture
- December 25 Execution of Nicolae Ceausescu, leader of Romania (b. 1918)